

Chapter 13 - Heart Formula

Ning Fuyi had thought that what would anger Chu Qingqiu should be the last phrase about "hypocritical pretense," but she hadn't expected that she would care more about the earlier phrase about "no connection."

This made Ning Fuyi feel strange.

But shouldn't she not care at all about my life and death?

Seeing Ning Fuyi's dark eyes looking exploringly into the depths of her eyes, Chu Qingqiu suddenly looked away, turned to the side, and the white silk in her sleeve also fell limply like losing strength, quietly withdrawing.

"My words are worth a thousand gold¹. Since I promised Ning Changfeng, I will not break my word and neglect to watch over you," Chu Qingqiu said indifferently. Then her figure turned and she strode away, disappearing into the sunlight outside the door.

"Tomorrow at the hour of the dragon². Don't forget," the last sentence seemed to float from beyond the heavens, echoing in Ning Fuyi's ears.

In this life, Chu Qingqiu's attitude was completely different from the previous life. In her past life, when she hoped for her help, she ignored her completely. In this life, when she was unwilling to have contact with her again, she instead took on the posture of an elder. How truly annoying. Ning Fuyi spat on the ground and irritably smoothed down her temple hair that had been messed up by the wind.

She didn't care what kind of fit Chu Qingqiu was having, only hoping she would interfere less and not ruin her grand plans.

"I'm avoiding you as much as I can, and still at the hour of the dragon? If I listen to you, I'm a little dog," Ning Fuyi muttered under her breath while flinging her sleeves and swaggering away.

The next morning, she stood outside Chu Qingqiu's Tranquil Mountain Palace³ with a dark face, standing straight and stiff.

Dog it is then. Right now she wanted nothing more than to bark three times loudly, then bite everyone in the palace to pieces.

"I'm already here. Can you untie me now?" Ning Fuyi helplessly turned her head toward Qiu Yi, who was watching her like a hawk.

"No way. Master said to wait until you're standing in front of her," Qiu Yi said loudly, holding a section of snow-white Flying Feather Rope⁴ in her hand.

"Is your brain missing a screw? I'm already like this - how could I run away?" Ning Fuyi was almost laughing from anger. Her entire upper body was now bound in rope, with only her shoulders exposed.

Qiu Yi didn't answer, only crossed her arms and glared at her angrily.

Ning Fuyi let out a long sigh and had to resign herself to stepping forward, entering the hall from yesterday.

Through the hollow screen, she could see shadowy figures inside. The scent of incense drifted from the room, accompanied by what seemed like Buddhist chanting from somewhere, making one's heart peaceful.

"Master, I've brought Ning Fuyi," Qiu Yi called out.

After a while, a simple "Enter" came from inside.

At the same time, the ropes on her body finally fell away, transforming into flying feathers that drifted back into the hall. Ning Fuyi frowned as she brought her hands back to her chest, rubbing her aching wrists.

Only then did she slowly walk in.

The woman was sitting cross-legged on a mat, her robes flowing like flower petals. Half her hair was bound at the crown with a jade hairpin, while the other half fell over her shoulders, covering her graceful waist. When she lifted her brush to write, her jade-white slender fingers contrasted sharply with the ink.

Even Ning Fuyi's gaze was fixed by such a scene for half a moment before she opened her mouth to mock.

"When commands don't work, you resort to binding. Truly worthy of Divine Venerable Chu Ling⁵, the white crane in the clouds."

"I am strict. When disciples don't listen, I sometimes use methods," Chu Qingqiu surprisingly wasn't angry, but answered with a normal expression. Then she gently put down her brush and gracefully stood up.

"What is this?" Ning Fuyi pointed at a stack of papers on the table.

"The heart techniques you need to memorize today," Chu Qingqiu said, extending her palm: "Sit."

Ning Fuyi's facial expression couldn't hold: "This many?"

"Not many. A total of one hundred eighty-four Water system heart formulas⁶. You're naturally slow, so just learning superficially won't help you progress. You need a solid foundation to have any possibility," Chu Qingqiu spoke these hurtful words as if they were completely ordinary. "No matter how many days it takes, memorize them all before reporting back to me."

"Take them away to memorize?" Ning Fuyi's eyes lit up.

"Memorize them here," Chu Qingqiu answered.

Ning Fuyi let out a long breath and quickly walked to the table, picking up the stack of papers to look. The ink was fresh - Chu Qingqiu must have written them just this morning.

This woman was truly terrifying.

"Isn't the Divine Venerable Wind system? How do you know so many Water system heart formulas? Besides, Elder Pingyao only said to consider it Water system for now. If I'm not, wouldn't this be a waste of effort?" Ning Fuyi still wanted to struggle.

"If you're skilled in one spell system, can you only learn that one? The Five Elements' all have common principles. Without knowing yourself and your enemy, you'll definitely hit bottlenecks later. Today you'll memorize Water system first, but you'll also need to learn all the other spell systems eventually. The hour of the dragon has arrived - don't delay any longer."

After Chu Qingqiu finished speaking, she waved her hand lightly, and Ning Fuyi immediately felt her legs fill with lead, plopping down on the mat with a thud.

She gasped and rubbed her knees. When she turned around again, Chu Qingqiu's figure was gone. She could only stare back at the papers on the table that were a finger's width thick, painfully wrinkling her face.

In her previous life, she had always believed in learning through practice, particularly disliking memorizing these bookish things like a nerd. Hadn't she still cultivated into a Demon King in the end? Chu Qingqiu was just too rigid.

Unfortunately, now she was under someone else's roof and had to bow her head. She could only pick up a page and pinch her eyelids to start memorizing.

Just one day, but for the next two, three, four consecutive days, she was bound and brought for morning cultivation each morning. After several days, she had only memorized half of the one hundred eighty-four heart formulas, making Ning Fuyi's anger grow day by day. By the fifth day, her resentment was almost overwhelming.

So Ning Fuyi decided she couldn't continue like this. She had to find a way to make Chu Qingqiu give up on personally instructing her.

Qiu Yi guarded the palace entrance like a stone block - escape was impossible. So she simply threw down the papers and began wandering randomly around the palace, preparing to cause some trouble that would anger Chu Qingqiu to death. This way Chu Qingqiu would know she was unteachable - rotten wood that couldn't be carved - and give up on instructing her early.

Unfortunately, this Tranquil Mountain Palace was boundlessly large. If she destroyed some flowers, grass, or buildings, it would be nothing to Chu Qingqiu. So Ning Fuyi abandoned the idea of smashing the palace and instead wandered into Chu Qingqiu's residence, a three-story pavilion.

As usual, Chu Qingqiu's barrier couldn't stop her at all, so she swaggered up to the highest floor and entered Chu Qingqiu's room.

The room's furnishings were elegant and refined, everywhere showing the bearing of an immortal. A few gardenia flowers were casually inserted here and there in the room. Chu Qingqiu sat cross-legged on a red wood couch, faint white light surrounding her, making the entire room seem hazy.

Ning Fuyi tiptoed behind her and waved her hand in front of her eyes, finding that Chu Qingqiu had no reaction.

Could she be in meditation? Ning Fuyi became a bit bolder, circling to Chu Qingqiu's front and lifting her eyelids.

"No way, still not waking up like this?" Ning Fuyi murmured in surprise, then felt her wrist. Her pulse was strong - nothing strange.

Could it be that when these Divine Venerables meditated, they weren't worried about anything?

When Ning Fuyi straightened up again, a mischievous smile curved her lips. She coughed and walked around the room with her hands behind her back. Seeing that the gardenia flowers on the wall were nice, she plucked one and stuck it in Chu Qingqiu's hair.

The white one looked quite good on her.

So Ning Fuyi waved her hand, and the white flower instantly became a striking crimson red. Only then did she nod with satisfaction.

One wasn't enough, so she plucked another and casually undid Chu Qingqiu's hair, arranging two buns on either side of her head and inserting red flowers.

This still wasn't enough. Ning Fuyi pondered for a while, then found a box of rouge from her chest, smiling as she dotted some red on her forehead and rubbed some on both cheeks, creating two rosy cheeks.

Seeing Chu Qingqiu transformed into this appearance, the gloating smile on her face could no longer be contained. But she felt something was still missing. Since the room was bare with no other fabrics, she reached out to untie the sash on Chu Qingqiu's outer robe.

She was trying to turn the outer robe red and then tie a big red butterfly-shaped knot at her chest.

But just as she had untied half of it, she heard a light cough behind her. Startled, she immediately turned around and looked in the direction of the sound.

She saw Chu Qingqiu standing gracefully outside the door with immortal bearing, holding a scroll in one hand and clenching the other behind her back, looking with a complex expression at the gaudily dressed "herself" on the bed.

And at "her" outer robe that had been half-untied by Ning Fuyi.

Footnotes:

- ¹ Words worth a thousand gold (一字千金) - A Chinese idiom meaning one's words are precious and reliable
- ² Hour of the dragon (辰时) - Traditional Chinese timekeeping; approximately 7-9 AM
- ³ Tranquil Mountain Palace (静山宫) - Chu Qingqiu's residence
- ⁴ Flying Feather Rope (飞羽索) - A magical binding tool made of connected feathers
- ⁵ Divine Venerable Chu Ling (褚凌神尊) - Chu Qingqiu's formal title
- ⁶ Heart formulas (心诀) - Fundamental incantations or meditation techniques used in cultivation
- ⁷ Five Elements (五行) - In Chinese philosophy: Wood, Fire, Earth, Metal, and Water; here referring to the five spell systems: Wind, Thunder, Water, Fire, and Wood